fault. It isn't anyone's fault. I just keep this feeling inside me; that I am not who I want to be.

A minute later, as she disappears, past the opticians that my dad runs and will still be running 25 years on, I turn around and walk back through the same park gates, in the opposite direction to her. I walk away from the school, up the road, a jacket zipped up over my uniform. The only purpose to begin with is to get as far as I can from it. I walk past the road my dad will teach me to drive on in two years' time. Up that road is where my grandad lives, where me and my cousin play cricket. He tells me to give him the strike while he hits sixes, and I oblige. Right next to it lies my nana's on Deepdale Drive, where the whole family go around on a Sunday night to have potato pie. I turn around again to double-check my mum is gone, and that no one from school has spotted me. Luckily, Sarah, my sister, doesn't know about this either, she goes to school on the other side of town. She's much more sensible, much more together than me, almost like a third parent, only reluctantly coming outside to play cricket with me with constant persuasion. Nobody knows, least of all me, that the road I look back on, where other parents park and let their children out for school, will one day be pitched to me as being renamed James Anderson Way, and that I will refuse to let them do that.

Burnley is dug in like a valley; a sudden, scooped freefall in the surrounding countryside, swallowing itself into entrenched, tightly packed roads, defunct cotton mills and close, community life. Only 90,000 of us call it home. It tests you to leave it. It almost dares you to try. The roads get ever steeper as you leave, at first suggesting and then insisting that you come back to where you came from. I walk past Burnley General Hospital, where I was born in scorching heat on 30 July 1982. I weighed nine and a half pounds on that day, my parents' second child, pushing myself up in my cot at three days old and turning my head to the opposite side. I didn't sleep much for two years, apparently, and was very alert. At seven months old, I was back in the same hospital, suffering with metatarsus adductus, where the front part of my foot curved inwards. A plaster cast was on until my first birthday but, as my mum tells me, it didn't stop me crawling around and getting about. I turn to walk up Torquay Avenue, beginning the climb that leads the way out of my town. I walk past the church I will be forced to sing at a funeral in, packed into pews and reciting 'Tears In Heaven' for